

instant messaging is part of the culture, Cothrel says, you should always send someone a note before dropping into his office. This gives the other person a chance to let you know if he's in the middle of something. It also saves you the trouble of walking over to his office only to find that he's gone home.

9. Log off instant messaging when you're not using it. I often leave my messaging program on when I'm not around and come back to find messages asking questions and other messages in which the senders ask why I'm ignoring them. One of these days, someone will send me an embarrassing message and there it will be on my computer screen, flashing for all to see. And it will be my own fault.
10. Never send an e-mail you wouldn't read in public. The night before his wedding, a Massachusetts state official sent a colleague an e-mail saying he wasn't sure he wanted to get married. Unfortunately, he hit Send All, and all state employees with e-mail accounts received the note. Boston Herald gossip reporters evidently received numerous forwarded copies, and they printed the message in the newspaper. Word is, the guy's fiancée married him anyway.
11. Think twice before forwarding e-mail. The jury remains out as to whether forwarding messages is acceptable. Obviously, it's sometimes necessary for business reasons, but people do it far more often than they need to. Philip Zimmermann, creator of Pretty Good Privacy encryption, has said he's not a fan of forwarding e-mails. How often would you even think of taking a handwritten letter you've received, making a photocopy, putting it in an envelope and sending it off to someone else? Zimmermann says the same thought and respect should go into forwarding e-mail.